something suspicious and unusual about it. Quickly, that area was encircled and Ravi knocked on the door. After a few minutes, a terrified old woman opened it and asked, ‘Who are you? What do you want?’

Ravi identified himself and demanded to know if there was anyone else in the house.

‘Only my daughter-in-law,’ she stuttered unconvincingly, pointing to a corner of the dimly lit room, where a young woman sat huddled up. Even in the poor light, Ravi could see her petrified look; she had fresh henna patterns on her hands.

‘You have my word that no harm will come to you, but I have to search this place,’ said Ravi with authority.

Quickly his men positioned themselves around the house, and the nominated search party commenced their job. Within five minutes they located a small hideout under the floor, accessible through a trap door, which was covered by a worn-out rug. When challenged, out came a nervous young man with his hands raised above his head.

‘Why were you hiding there?’ demanded the major.

‘Sahib, mujhe maut ka khauf hai (I was scared for my life)’, he cowered in fear.

‘What is your name?’ asked Ravi.

‘Abdul Majid, sir’, he replied, shaking.

Ravi took out his notebook to check his list, which confirmed his suspicions. When confronted with information about his terrorist background, Abdul Majid broke down and fell at the major’s feet, seeking forgiveness.

The old woman, in a state of shock, began sobbing. Regaining her composure after a few moments, she came up to the major and touched his chin as a gesture of respect and deference. ‘Sahib, don’t take him away. He is my only son and his “nikah” was done only a few days ago. Take pity on this young bride,’ she implored. The girl looked stunned and slowly slid to the ground.

‘Mother, tell him to be honest and to cooperate. I assure you of his life and safety’, said Ravi to the woman.

‘He will, he will; and may God bless you,’ she responded.